

ALL CREATURES GREAT AND SMALL (BBC/Masterpiece, 2020 onwards)

Personal Viewing Journal -- Rewatch

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I began rewatching this series in November 2025, starting from the first episode. Harry and I discovered it together years ago on PBS. He liked Siegfried. I like James. I am writing down my thoughts this time through because writing things down keeps me company in the evenings.

SERIES 1

Episode 1 -- "Beginners"

James Herriot arrives in Darrowby and meets the Farnons. The Yorkshire Dales in winter. I had forgotten how quiet the opening is; no big dramatic music, just the landscape and James being hopelessly out of his depth.

Tristan is already charming and useless in the best way. I could see right away why Harry liked Siegfried. There is something about a man who is blustery and kind underneath it.

Mrs. Hall is the one I respond to most. She runs that household and never once asks to be thanked. I know something about that.

Episode 2 -- "Andante"

The cow rescue in the rain. James is completely undone and Siegfried gives him a bit of grace when he least expects it. I cried a little, which is something I did not expect to do at a scene involving a stuck cow.

The scene at the end where James sits down to supper with the family and they are all just talking at once and the warmth of it is palpable. It reminded me of Sunday dinners here when the children were young.

Episode 3 -- "New Beginnings"

The dog chapter. I will not say more. I sat very still for a long time after.

Episode 4 -- "Home Truths"

Helen enters more fully this episode. She is not what James expects. She is more than he expects, which is the right kind of surprise in a romance.

There is a scene where Mrs. Hall talks to Siegfried about something that happened to her in the past and the restraint with which it is written is impressive. Good writing trusts the viewer to understand what is not said aloud. I appreciate that.

Episode 5 -- "All's Fair"

The relationship between Tristan and his studying continues to entertain me greatly. The scenes between him and Siegfried remind me of Brian and Harry's relationship: one of them always exasperated, the other always privately amused.

Episode 6 -- "The Pig Man"

The pig man is magnificent. The animal scenes in this series are handled with such care. I have thought about this often; they could have played those scenes for laughs and they mostly did not.

SERIES 2

Episode 1 -- "Breath of Fresh Air"

The war is approaching and you can feel it underneath every conversation. The show handles this with a kind of

measured grief that is honest and not overwrought.

I watched this one on a night when the wind was terrible and the house felt very large and quiet and I was glad to have something to watch.

Episode 2 -- "It Takes All Sorts"

The new vet students. I liked this episode for the same reason I like Emily's nursing school stories. There is something moving about people just beginning to learn how to care for living things.

Episode 3 -- "Perfect Timing"

Helen and James. I will not spoil it for myself in writing but I will say that when something good happens after you have been waiting for it patiently, there is a particular satisfaction that is different from a sudden good thing.

Harry proposed to me in a kitchen. Not a romantic location. But he was nervous and that was romantic.

Episode 4 -- "From the Heart"

Tristan's musical talent revealed, which I had forgotten was coming. I laughed out loud, then was sorry there was no one in the room to laugh with.

I called Peggy afterward and described the scene to her. She had not seen the series. I told her she should watch it and she said maybe she would.

Episode 5 -- "All Creatures Great and Small"

The title episode. The reading of the poem at the end of the episode, or the echo of it, did what it was meant to do. I am not too old to be moved by something familiar said freshly.

Episode 6 -- "The Price"

The harder episode of the series. War takes people away and the show does not flinch from that. It is shot in a way that makes absence visible, which is a difficult thing to do well.

I thought about Harry quite a bit during this one.

SERIES 3

Episode 1 -- "Keeping Up Appearances"

It was good to come back to Darrowby after the emotional weight of the Series 2 finale. This episode is lighter on its feet and I was grateful for it.

Mrs. Hall's storyline is developing in a direction I find satisfying. She deserves her own chapter.

Episode 2 -- "Holding the Fort"

Siegfried on his own without James for a few days. Everything goes sideways in an orderly fashion. I related to this entirely. Running things is easier when nobody is watching but you still have to run them.

Episode 3 -- "A Tricky Business"

Mrs. Pumphrey and Tricky Woo return. Pure pleasure. The friendship between Mrs. Pumphrey and James is one of my favorite things in the series; it is tender without being sentimental.

I made a cup of chamomile tea and watched this twice.

Episode 4 -- "Papers"

The bureaucratic episode. There is a running tension in the show between the warmth of the practice and the cold machinery of war and officialdom, and this episode brings it into focus. James is patient. James is always patient. I admire that.

Episode 5 -- "The Bees"

I grew up hearing that bees were important. My grandmother kept them. This episode made me feel that in a way that is hard to articulate. Something about care and attention given to small living things over years.

Episode 6 -- "How Things Are"

The series finale is exactly as quiet and good as I hoped it would be. I do not want to write too much and flatten it. I will let it sit and decide when to start Series 4.

GENERAL NOTES

What I love about this show, having now watched it twice, is that it is honest about difficulty without being defeated by it. The characters bear a great deal. Difficult births, losses, the approach of war, personal loneliness. And they keep going. They get up and go to the next farm and do the next thing.

I know something about that too.

I will begin Series 4 when I feel ready. Probably February.

Joanne Lawton

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